welcomed rather than opposed improved Sino-US relations—but not if they came at India's expense.[260]

The Indian response to American attempts to brief officials on the president's trip to China reflected the tension between the two countries. On March 28, Keating tried to meet Gandhi to brief her on Nixon's trip to China, but he was told to meet the foreign minister instead—this was the first time she had refused to see the ambassador. Swaran Singh, in turn, commented that everything Keating told him had already been made public. Other than asking if further trips were planned, he did not say much on the subject.[261] From the US perspective, he did, however, say more than enough on another subject: Vietnam. The foreign minister publicly condemned the US resumption of bombing of North Vietnam in statements that the US thought were "unbalanced" and stemming from "pique." Gandhi herself called the US action "deplorable."[262] These statements came despite Indian awareness of the issue's negative impact in the past on US-India relations.[263]

As a sign of goodwill, at the beginning of the year, Keating had recommended that the administration resume aid to India.[264] Even after the president's China trip, however, the White House was in no hurry to do so.[265] Policymakers were annoyed about the Indian statements on Vietnam, and they also continued to be concerned about China's reaction. One of the initiatives that had been affected by the aid suspension was the Peace Indigo program, a communication system designed to connect the early-warning radar system that the US had provided India for use at the Sino-Indian border after the 1962 war. When the question arose of what to do—because the suspension was driving particular US companies to the brink of bankruptcy—Kissinger's most pressing question was how the program "related to China."[266]

Senior State and Defense Department officials agreed that the US should continue to "play it cool" with India. The "best way" to get India to come calling was for Washington "to have a success in Moscow, to continue the normalization of our relations with China and to have a stable government in Pakistan."[267]

CIA analysts indicated, however, that the Indian government seemed disinclined to take the initiative and, regardless, was unlikely to respond to any US initiative. NSC staffers suggested that given this assessment, "Perhaps what is needed first is a more gradual repair job with softer words